

Habitat

As part of Montreal's Expo 1967 world fair, Canadian-Israeli architect Moshe Safdie (b.1938) created a built environment of 158 apartments as his first major work. He had worked on the idea when preparing his university thesis. Inspired by clustered ancient hill homes in Italy, Spain and the Middle East, the apartments are constructed from 354 individual prefabricated concrete units, each stacked in seemingly haphazard arrangements, and connected by internal steel cables. The scheme fulfilled Safdie's vision of affordable, mass-produced family housing. Known as Habitat, the structure has the appearance of an arbitrary stack of boxes, but in reality Safdie planned the arrangement to feature rhythmic projections and recessions, and to create areas of privacy and light. An environmentally sensitive air-conditioning system also provides water for a series of terraced swimming pools. After the world fair, Habitat became one of the most fashionable addresses in Montreal, an example of both brutalism and architectural pop art.

